the banned Students Islamic Movement of India (SIMI), with help from the Lashkar-e-Toiba. The Mumbai Police Crime Branch later claimed it was the act of an Indian Mujahideen module that it had busted.

QUESTION OF LAW

The final set of arrestees was tried by a special court under MCOCA (Maharashtra Control of Organised Crime Act, 1999) and the National Investigation Agency (NIA) Act, 2008. In September 2015, the 12 accused were convicted; five of them got the death sentence, seven got life. One of those slated for capital punishment met his end via COVID infection in 2021, awaiting appeal in Nagpur jail.

Takeaways

- **The Bombay HC acquits the 12 accused in the July 2006 suburban train bomb blasts**
- **The verdict cites a flawed probe, hurting the reliability of terror investigations**

The high court said the prosecution had "utterly failed to establish the offence beyond reasonable doubt... on each count". The bench, comprising Justice Anil Kilor and Justice Shyam Chandak, said the impugned judgment and order of conviction and sentence "are liable to be quashed and set aside". It challenged the admissibility of the confessional statements on various grounds, including whether they were voluntarily made or extorted under torture, also whether MCOCA could apply retrospectively.

CM Devendra Fadnavis called it a "shocking decision". The state has moved the Supreme Court against the verdict. The deceased's kin, too, expressed their anguish. In the end, India's law-enforcement and criminal justice system have hurt the reliability of our terror investigations. ■

▶ KARNATAKA

SIDDA MEDICINE FOR SELF-HEALING

Is he going? Yes, going great guns. A favourable SC verdict caps a good run for a beleaguered CM

By **Ajay Sukumaran**

OVER TWO YEARS as a Congress CM, the one thing Siddaramaiah hasn't been able to shake off is dogged speculation about a mid-term change of guard. For that, he has his own partymen to thank. Case in point: the fresh spell of theorising spurred by a cryptic comment by cooperation minister K.N. Rajanna, a Sidda loyalist, about an 'upheaval' in September. It took multiple visits by AICC Karnataka in-charge Randeep Surjewala to tamp down on the buzz, even if tenuously. Amidst parleys with MLAs, Surjewala told reporters on July 1: "Some of you asked me...are you taking opinions on a leadership change. The answer is clearly no," he said, flanked by deputy CM D.K. Shivakumar, the one biding time for the top post.

Since then, the CM appears to have bolstered his image on a few key fronts. He occupied pride of place at the party's OBC advisory council meet in Bengaluru on July 16, leaving little doubt about the value placed on his appeal among the underclasses. There, the party adopted the Bengaluru Declaration, demanding a national caste census *a la* Telangana, ending the 50 per cent cap on reservation, and quotas in private educational institutions.

ANI



FOLLOW THE LEADER Karnataka CM Siddaramaiah, trailed by Dy CM D.K. Shivakumar, in Mysuru, Jul. 19